

Impact: High Difficulty: Easy-Medium Misuse risk: Low

WHY IT WORKS

Ambiguous requests create ambiguous responses — when people do not know exactly what is needed, they either do nothing or do the wrong thing. A clean request removes interpretation and makes it easy to say yes.

WHAT IT IS (AND ISN'T)

- Not bossiness — a clean request is easier to decline than a vague one, which is what makes it fair.
- Not a demand dressed up in politeness — the other person keeps a real choice.
- It is removing the guesswork: what, by when, and why it matters, in one breath.

THE PAYOFF

How it lands: I always know exactly what they need from me — helping them is easy.

Principle: People say yes more often, and resent it less, when the ask is specific enough to evaluate.

What you gain

- Fewer rounds of clarifying back-and-forth
- Higher-quality results delivered first time
- A reputation for being easy to help
- Less chasing and fewer missed expectations
- More honest nos — which protects the relationship

Why most people fail at it

- They hint instead of asking, then feel resentful when the hint is missed.
- They soften the ask until the deadline disappears.
- They bundle three requests into one and get none of them.
- They mistake vagueness for politeness.

CORE FORMULA

What you need -> By when -> Why it matters -> One ask — stop

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Before making any request, answer: what specifically do I need, and by when? State those two things. Leave out the rest.

BEST FOR

- Delegating tasks clearly
- Asking colleagues for help without ambiguity
- Setting expectations in professional relationships
- Reducing back-and-forth caused by unclear requests

METHOD, STEP BY STEP

1. Specify — Say exactly what you need

Name the deliverable concretely enough that they could hand it to you without another question. 'Look at this' is not a request; 'check the numbers in the summary table' is.

Vague: 'Can you take a look at the report?'

Specific: 'Can you sanity-check the revenue figures on page 2?'

2. Anchor — Attach the deadline

A request without a time is a wish. Give a real deadline — and if it is genuinely flexible, say what 'soon' actually means.

Wish: 'Whenever you get a chance.'

Anchored: 'By Thursday morning, so I can include it in the pack.'

3. Motivate — Give the one-line why

One sentence on why it matters converts the request from an order into a shared goal. More than one sentence and you are justifying, not motivating.

Why: 'It feeds straight into the board pack.'

Why: 'I cannot book the venue until I have your yes.'

4. Stop — One ask — then silence

Make the single most important request and stop talking. Stacked asks compete; the pause gives them room to say yes, no, or 'not by then' honestly.

Stacked: '...and while you are in there, could you also update the...'

Clean: 'That is the one thing I need. Anything unclear?'

FIELD TIP

The kindest request is the clearest one.

Vague asks feel polite to make but are expensive to receive — the other person has to reconstruct what you actually need. Precision is a gift: it lets them succeed on the first attempt.

Situation: You need a colleague's review before a client call.

Don't: 'If you get a chance, could you maybe look at the deck at some point?'

Do: 'Can you review slides 3-8 by 2 pm? The client call is at 3.'

PHRASE BANK

Clean Request Core · What, when, why

- "I need X from you by Thursday at 5 pm."
- "Could you do X? I need it before the 3 pm call."
- "One specific thing: I need you to..."
- "I have a simple request — can you...?"
- "The ask is: please send me X by end of day."
- "I need your input on one thing before tomorrow."
- "Can you confirm you have received this and flag any blockers?"
- "The deliverable I need from you is X."

Request Follow-Up · Confirming and clarifying

- "Does that feel doable by then?"
- "Any blockers I should know about?"
- "Let me know if the scope is unclear."
- "Flag me if that timeline does not work."
- "Does anything in that ask need clarification?"
- "I want to make sure that lands clearly — any questions?"

Micro-Requests · Small asks, zero ambiguity

- "Two minutes of your time before 3?"
- "One favour: send me the link when you get a second."
- "Quick one — can you confirm yes or no by lunch?"
- "Can you glance at this today? One paragraph."
- "When you are next at your desk, can you forward me the file?"

Delegation Requests · Handing work over cleanly

- "I would like you to own this end to end — scope is X, deadline is Friday."
- "The outcome I need is X. How you get there is your call."
- "Success looks like: the client signs off without a second round."
- "You have the full decision on everything except budget — that comes back to me."

- "Check in with me at the halfway point, otherwise it is yours."
- "If you hit a blocker, bring it to me within a day rather than sitting on it."

Personal Asks · Clean requests in close relationships

- "It would mean a lot if you could be there on Saturday."
- "Can I ask you for a proper favour, and you can absolutely say no?"
- "What would really help me this week is one evening without plans."
- "I need a hand with something — is Sunday morning any good?"
- "Would you read this and tell me honestly what you think?"

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: Vague: 'Could you look at this at some point?'
Better: Can you review this when you get a chance?
Best: Can you review section 3 and send your notes by Thursday noon?
2. Weak: Over-explaining before making the ask
Better: I have a project that needs input — can you help?
Best: 'I need your input on X by [date]. Context: one sentence.' Then stop.
3. Weak: Multiple bundled requests in one message
Better: I have a few things — can we go through them?
Best: One clean request. Then a second message for the next one.

DECISION TREE

If You have a vague request in mind

Answer: what specifically? By when? Then make the request.
"I need X completed by Y. Let me know if anything is unclear."

If The other person does not know why the task matters

Add one sentence on the stakes.
"This feeds into the board meeting, so I need it by Wednesday."

If You are making multiple requests at once

Make the most important one. Do not bundle.
"One thing for now — can you do X? I will follow up with the rest."

If The request was not done to spec

Clarify what was missing rather than blame.
"I should have been clearer — what I actually needed was..."

If Someone asks a vague favour

Ask: what specifically and when?
"Happy to help — what do you need and when?"

SCENARIOS

Delegating a task to a team member

What, by when, what good looks like. — "Can you have the first draft of X ready by Friday at noon? Three pages max."

Asking a busy senior person for something

Crisp ask up front, one line of context. — "I need five minutes of your time before the 3 pm call to get your sign-off on the approach."

Following up because a task was not done

Restate the request clearly rather than criticising. — "I wanted to follow up on X — could you get that to me today?"

Asking for help from a peer

Specific ask with a respectful timeline. — "Could you look over this proposal and flag any gaps? I need it back by Wednesday."

WORKED EXAMPLE

Without the technique

You: It would be great if someone could kind of look at this when they get a chance.
(Three days pass with no response.)

With the technique

You: Can you review section 2 of this doc and give me your feedback by Thursday? Thirty minutes should be enough.
Colleague: Sure — I'll have it to you Wednesday.

COMMON MISTAKES

Hinting instead of asking

Sounds like: 'It would be great if someone could deal with the invoices...'
Better: 'Sam, can you process the invoices by Friday?'

The vanishing deadline

Sounds like: 'No rush at all, whenever suits.'
Better: 'Genuinely not urgent — any time before the end of the month.'

Bundling requests

Sounds like: 'Can you do X, and also Y, and maybe Z if there is time?'
Better: 'The priority is X by Friday. I will come back to the rest separately.'

Justifying at length

Sounds like: Three paragraphs of background before the ask
Better: 'One-line why, then the ask — context available on request.'

Asking without an owner

Sounds like: 'Can someone pick this up?' (to a group)
Better: 'Alex — can you own this one?'

READING THE ROOM

Signs it is working

- Things get done more often without follow-up chasing.
- People come back with fewer clarifying questions.
- You get fewer vague or incomplete responses.
- You feel clearer about what you need before you ask.

Signs to adjust

- Requests feel cold or demanding.
- The person needs context you skipped.
- You are asking for too many things at once.
- Important expectations (quality, format) are assumed rather than stated.

WHEN NOT TO USE

- When the relationship is such that a formal request would feel clinical or cold.
- In brainstorming contexts where you want open-ended input rather than a specific deliverable.
- When you genuinely do not know what you need — clarify that first, then make the request.

RECOVERY LINES

Best line: 'I should have been clearer — what I actually need is X by Y.'

- "That was vaguer than I meant. The specific ask is this."
- "I should have been clearer — what I actually need is X by Y."
- "Let me re-ask that properly."
- "I realise I never gave you a deadline. It is Thursday."
- "I stacked three asks there. The one that matters is the first."

- "My ask was unclear, so the miss is on me. Can we reset it?"

TECHNIQUE CHAINS

Delegation chain

Clean request -> why it matters -> check for blockers -> confirm ownership

I need the client summary drafted by Wednesday noon.

It goes straight into Thursday's pitch.

Any blockers I should know about now?

Great — it is yours. Flag me if anything shifts.

Favour chain

Permission -> clean ask -> genuine opt-out -> thanks

Can I ask you a real favour?

I need a lift to the airport on Sunday at 7.

It is completely fine to say no — I have a backup.

You are a legend. I owe you one.

RELATED TECHNIQUES

TC003 — BLUF: Bottom Line Up Front

BLUF puts the request in the first sentence of a longer message — the ask is the bottom line.

TC015 — Next-Step Close

Next-Step Close is the meeting-level version: one owner, one action, one deadline.

TC012 — Boundary Without Blame

Boundary Without Blame is the mirror image — how to answer someone else's request with a clean no.

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Audit your requests

Review one request you made today. Was it specific? Did it include a deadline? Could it be cleaner?

Day 2 — What and when

For every request you make today, include both what you need and by when.

Day 3 — One ask at a time

Send your requests as separate messages rather than bundled. Notice if clarity improves.

Day 4 — The why in one line

Add one line of context to an important request. Just one line.

Day 5 — Confirm understanding

After making a request, ask: 'Anything unclear?' once. Not repeatedly.

Day 6 — Written requests

Rewrite one email request to strip it down: ask first, context second, no filler.

Day 7 — Calibration

Did your requests land better this week? Were there fewer follow-up questions or missed deadlines?

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I state the request specifically — not vaguely?
- Did I include a clear deadline or timeline?
- Did I make one request, not several bundled together?
- Did I add context only where genuinely needed?
- Did I confirm understanding without nagging?
- Was the request clear enough that the person did not have to guess what I meant?
- Did I avoid making the request sound like a demand or an instruction?